

Making sounds

Many animals make sounds, but humans are the only animals that can communicate using spoken words. Both speech and language are controlled by your brain. It sends out instructions that make your respiratory (breathing) system produce sounds that can be understood by those around you.

WHAT IS SOUND?

Throw a pebble into a pond and circular ripples will move outward from the point of impact. In the same way, if you pluck a guitar string so it vibrates, sound waves will move outward through the air. These sound waves are picked up by your ears.

WOW!

Men have deeper voices than women because their vocal cords are longer and vibrate more slowly.

VOICE BOX

The vocal cords in your voice box (larynx) make the sounds that are shaped into speech. These cords are separated when you are silent and breathing normally. When you speak, your brain sends signals to the voice box muscles to pull the vocal cords together and make them tight. When air pushes between these muscles, they vibrate and create sounds.

